

THE STUDY • CHARITÉ BERLIN • RANDOMIZED TRIAL • 2015

Can meditation ease long-standing neck pain? A randomized trial in patients with chronic neck pain and psychological distress



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52%

WITH SOS MEDITATION

vs.

14%

WITH HOME EXERCISE

After 8 weeks, patients with long-standing chronic neck pain cut their *pain at rest* by more than half – *over 3×* the drop seen with home exercise.



WHO

Chronic neck pain patients

89 patients (mean age 50, 82% women) who had lived with chronic neck pain for an average of 11 years, with elevated stress.



WHAT

8 wks of meditation, weekly class

SOS meditation (then called Jyoti): a 90-minute weekly class plus daily home practice. Compared to a home-based neck exercise program.



WE FOUND

Pain at rest dropped sharply

On a 0–100 pain scale, the meditation group fell from 46 to 22. The exercise group barely moved (44 → 38). Group difference was statistically significant.



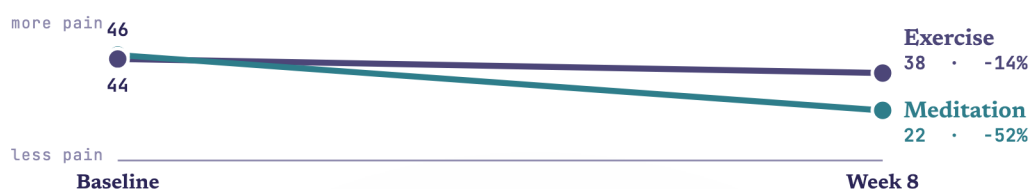
AND

Less suffering, too

Patients in the meditation group said the pain interfered with and troubled their daily life less — a meaningful clinical signal beyond the pain score itself.

PRIMARY OUTCOME

Pain at rest, on a 0–100 scale



↓ **Pain at rest dropped from 46 to 22 in the meditation group.** In the exercise group it barely moved (44 → 38). Group difference was statistically significant ($P = .02$).

BEYOND PAIN AT REST An honest look at what changed – and what didn't.

- ✓ **MEDITATION OUTPERFORMED EXERCISE ON:** Pain at rest · Pain-related bothersomeness
- ⓘ **NO SIGNIFICANT GROUP DIFFERENCE ON:** Pain at motion · Anxiety & depression scores · Quality of life (meditation showed non-significant edge on most)

→ **SOS meditation was called *Jyoti* meditation when this trial was conducted.** The practice is the same: silent, eyes-closed inward attention with a repeated calming word.

HOW TO READ THIS

Randomized but unblinded; active-control comparison vs. home exercise. $n = 89$ (intention-to-treat analysis with multiple imputation); 38% lost to follow-up. 8-week endpoint; no long-term data. Sample: German adults with chronic neck pain & elevated stress.

CITATION

Jeitler M, Brunnhuber S, Meier L, Lütke R, Büssing A, Kessler C, Michalsen A (2015). Effectiveness of Jyoti meditation for patients with chronic neck pain and psychological distress – a randomized controlled clinical trial. *The Journal of Pain* 16(1):77–86. German Clinical Trials Register: DRKS00000373.

